was derived from a projection by the National Skill Development Corporation that India's retail workforce would reach about 56 million by 2022, with Luxury Connect assuming that 10% would be associated with luxury. It was a broad estimate of potential talent demand, not a count of actual vacancies.

The underlying capability challenge, however, remains relevant. In a 2012 survey of luxury company heads and brand owners conducted by Luxury Connect, 69.2% said they wanted to hire people trained specifically for luxury. The most frequently cited problem on the shop floor, identified by 34.9% of respondents, was a lack of understanding of luxury standards. A lack of dedicated training and a lack of a luxury outlook were each cited by 23.3%, while 18.6% pointed to inadequate product knowledge.

Gupta's assessment is that the gap goes beyond knowing the products or being able to describe a brand. "The gap is not product knowledge; it is judgement," he says. Digital fluency is becoming relevant, too. Customer relationship management, digital clienteling, analytics, omnichannel retail and AI-assisted personalisation can support the customer experience, but they do not replace the judgement required to use these tools appropriately.

There is, however, an important limitation in measuring the gap. India does not yet have a comprehensive, publicly available luxury-specific workforce dataset that establishes the number of people employed in luxury-related sectors, the additional jobs being created or the number of appropriately skilled professionals available to fill them.

## BUILDING A HOMEGROWN BRAND

The talent question is not limited to international luxury houses. As Indian brands seek to build stronger identities and reach wider markets, they need professionals who can combine an understanding of local consumers with the business capabilities required to scale.

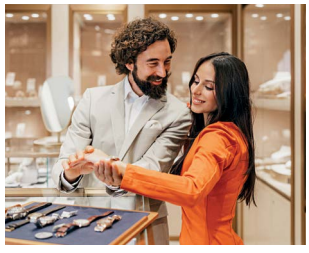
Vaibhav Karnavat, Founder of House of Quadri—a premium lab-grown diamond jewellery brand—says homegrown brands are not necessarily facing a shortage of craftsmanship, products or supply-chain capabilities. The harder task is building the customer experience, brand identity and sophisticated presentation needed to compete with established international players.

Building a homegrown brand also differs from bringing an established international brand into In-



### Beauty, watches, jewellery, and premium consumer brands

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### Indian luxury and design-led businesses

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